

Every time you open it, you see whether you are on pace to finish.

You have two files: **Dissertation-Writing-Tracker.xlsx** — the workbook — and this guide. The tracker covers the **writing phase** of a thesis or dissertation, Masters or PhD. You log each writing session; the Dashboard turns your log into one honest number: the words per day you need to finish on time.

What this file does

- Tracks **every chapter** against its word goal and due date — a progress bar fills as you write.
- Turns your session log into **pace**: total words vs. goal, words per day needed, this week vs. last week.
- Keeps a **writing streak** and your active days, so momentum is visible, not imagined.
- Tracks **revision rounds** (R1–R4) and counts down to **submission and defense**, with a 12-task last-mile checklist.

What it does not do

- It does **not manage your literature or sources** — it tracks writing, nothing else.
- It is **not a whole-PhD planner** — no experiments, no funding, no coursework. Writing phase only.
- It gives **no academic or university-policy advice**. Your institution's rules always win.
- It contains **no macros** and needs no add-in, no account and no internet connection.

THE SEVEN SHEETS, IN THE ORDER YOU WILL USE THEM

SHEET	WHAT IT IS FOR
1 · Start Here	The five-minute tour: what goes where, the capacity, the demo-cleanup list. Read it once.
2 · Dashboard	Your pace, live — 15 tiles, a chapter mini-table and the next deadlines. Nothing to type; the sheet is protected (no password) so you cannot type over a formula by accident.
3 · Chapters	One row per chapter: name, word goal, due date, status. Words written and the progress bar pull themselves from your session log.
4 · Writing Sessions	One row per session — date, chapter, minutes, words. Twenty seconds of logging; that is the whole habit.
5 · Revisions	One row per feedback round: who it came from, when it is due, where it stands.
6 · Submission & Defense	Your key dates — the countdowns hang off them — plus the 12-task checklist for the last mile.
7 · Lists	All dropdown values, visible and yours to edit. No hidden sheets anywhere.

OPENING THE FILE

Excel (2016 or newer): double-click `Dissertation-Writing-Tracker.xlsx`. If a yellow “Protected View” bar appears, click **Enable Editing** — that bar shows for every downloaded file, there is nothing more to unblock.

Google Sheets: see page 6 — a three-step import, and the formulas, dropdowns and colours all survive the trip.

LibreOffice Calc opens the file out of the box.

The file arrives as a working demo, not an empty shell. Five example chapters, fourteen writing sessions and three revision rounds are already in there, so every tile on the Dashboard is alive the moment you open it. The demo dates are written as `=TODAY()-n`, so the demo never looks stale. Page 2 removes it safely.

Questions? Message me on Etsy — I reply within 48 hours.

Set up in three steps — about five minutes.

Before you start, click through the demo once: open **Chapters** and watch the grey columns work, then open **Dashboard** and see the same rows turned into pace. Then do these three steps in order.

1 MINUTE 0–2 · THE ONLY DESTRUCTIVE STEP

Clear the demo — contents only

Select the cells below and press **Delete** (clear contents). That is all. The exact demo cells:

- **Chapters** — the entries in rows **5–9**
- **Writing Sessions** — the entries in rows **5–18**
- **Revisions** — the entries in rows **5–7**
- **Submission & Defense** — the two demo dates in **C5** and **C6**, and set the three demo checklist statuses in **E11**, **E13** and **E15** back to *Not started*

Never delete whole rows. Clear the **contents** of the demo cells — select them and press Delete. Right-click → “Delete rows” would rip out the grey formulas with them and stop the bottom of the sheet from calculating. (If it already happened: page 8 tells you how to recover.)

2 MINUTE 2–4 · CHAPTERS + SUBMISSION & DEFENSE

Enter your thesis

On **Chapters**, one row per chapter: name, **word goal**, due date, status. Give every chapter a **unique name** and avoid *****, **?** and **~** in names — sessions are matched to chapters by their exact name. Already mid-thesis? Put the words you have into **Starting words** — progress starts from there, nothing is lost. Then open **Submission & Defense** and type your **submission deadline into C5** and your **defense date into C6** — the countdowns and the words-per-day number hang off these two cells.

3 MINUTE 4–5 · WRITING SESSIONS

Log your first session

One row: today's date, the chapter from the dropdown, minutes, words. Cut more than you wrote? **Negative numbers are allowed.** Now open the **Dashboard**: total words, % of goal, words per day needed, your streak — all live. From here on, one row after every session is the entire routine.

THE TWO RULES THAT KEEP THE FILE HEALTHY

Yellow = you type. Grey = it calculates itself.

Never type in a grey cell: you would overwrite a formula and the sheet would quietly stop being right. If it happens by accident, press **Ctrl/Cmd+Z** straight away. Capacity: **25 chapters · 300 sessions · 100 revision rounds**, all rows pre-filled with formulas — always type into the **next empty pre-filled row**. Rows beyond the capacity are not counted; for a second thesis, duplicate the file.

Inserting rows: always copy an existing formula row — never insert an empty row. An inserted blank row has none of the grey formulas, so its numbers never reach the Dashboard. You should not need to insert rows at all — the next pre-filled row is always the right place. If you must insert one (say, to keep chapters in order), copy a pre-filled row and use **Insert copied cells**, then overwrite its yellow cells.

The Dashboard, tile by tile.

Fifteen tiles, one line each. Everything updates itself from the other sheets — the Dashboard has no input cell at all.

TILE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Total words written	Starting words plus everything you have logged, across all chapters.
Total word goal	The sum of your chapter goals. Shows “—” until you set goals.
% of goal	Written ÷ goal, capped at 100%.
Words/day needed	The core number — see the box below.
Days to submission	Counts down from your deadline in Submission & Defense C5.
Words this week	Everything logged since Monday. Weeks start on Monday, everywhere in the file.
Words last week	The full previous week — your honest comparison line.
Sessions / Minutes this week	How often you sat down, and for how long.
Days to defense	Counts down from C6.
Writing streak (days)	Consecutive days with at least one session, ending today. Page 7 explains it honestly.
Active days — last 7	On how many of the last seven days you wrote at all — the kinder number.
Best session (words)	Your record session, for the bad days.
Avg words / session	What a normal sitting actually produces — useful for planning real days.
Next revision due (days)	The nearest open feedback round. Negative and red = overdue — it does not vanish.

Below the tiles: a **chapter mini-table** (the first 8 chapters; a “+N more” line points to the Chapters sheet) and the **next chapter deadlines** — the three nearest due dates, overdue chapters first, in red.

THE PACE MATH, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

(word goal – words written) ÷ calendar days until submission = words per day needed.

Calendar days, weekends included — deadlines do not skip them. Every session you log makes tomorrow's number a little smaller; every day that passes without one makes it a little bigger. When the goal is reached, the tile shows 0; without a deadline in C5 or without word goals, it shows “—” — it never guesses.

CHAPTERS — WHAT THE GREY COLUMNS DO

Words written & the bar

Words written = your starting words + every session logged for that exact chapter name. The **progress bar** fills in tenths — and the full bar is reserved for a true 100%: at 96% you see 9 of 10 blocks. This file rounds down, not up.

Days left & starting mid-thesis

Days left counts down to each chapter's due date — red under 8 days, amber under 22. A chapter set to *Final* goes quiet. Starting with existing text? **Starting words** is exactly for that: type what you have once, and the bar starts from there.

Logging sessions, tracking revisions.

WRITING SESSIONS — THE TWENTY-SECOND HABIT

After every session, one row: **date** (as `yyyy-mm-dd`), **chapter** from the dropdown, **minutes**, **words**, and a note if you want one. That is the entire input this product ever asks of you.

- **Negative words are allowed.** An editing day where you cut 300 words is a real writing day — log it as `-300`. Your totals stay honest and the streak still counts the day.
- **Pick the chapter from the dropdown** rather than typing it. Sessions are matched to chapters by their **exact name** — a typo or a stray space sends the words nowhere.
- **Several sessions on one day are fine.** The streak and “Active days” count the day once; the words all count.
- The grey **Week** column labels each row with its ISO week (`W33`). It is also your early-warning light: if it stays **empty** next to a date you typed, that date was saved as text — retype it as `yyyy-mm-dd` (more on page 8).

REVISIONS — FEEDBACK ROUNDS R1 TO R4

One row per feedback round: the **chapter**, the **round** (R1–R4), **who** the feedback came from (Advisor, Committee, Peer, Self), when you **received** it, when your revision is **due**, and its **status**.

- **Open rounds stay loud.** *Not started* and *In progress* keep their countdown running — red under 8 days, and an overdue round shows negative days on the Dashboard instead of quietly disappearing.
- **Submitted and Done go quiet.** Set the status and the countdown shows “—” — that round stops nagging you.
- The Dashboard tile “**Next revision due**” always shows the nearest open round, so the next thing you owe someone is one glance away.

A workable rhythm: log the session right after you stop writing, while the word count is still on screen — and enter a feedback round the day it lands in your inbox. Both take under half a minute, and from that moment the file watches the deadline for you.

TWO DETAILS WORTH KNOWING

Renaming a chapter

Sessions match by exact name. If you rename a chapter on **Chapters**, rename it in the logged sessions too — find & replace does it in seconds. Note that **pasting** into the chapter column can bypass the dropdown, so paste carefully.

Weeks start on Monday

“Words this week” runs from Monday to today; “Words last week” is the full previous Monday-to-Sunday week. The W-labels in the session log use ISO weeks, the international standard.

The last mile, on one page.

KEY DATES — THREE CELLS THAT DRIVE THE COUNTDOWNS

On **Submission & Defense**, three yellow date cells:

- **C5 — final submission deadline.** Drives “Days to submission” **and** the words-per-day number on the Dashboard. This is the one date the whole file leans on.
- **C6 — defense date.** Drives “Days to defense”.
- **C7 — post-defense revisions due**, if your university has that stage. Leave it empty until you need it.

Each date shows its own days-left counter next to it — red under 8 days, amber under 22, green beyond.

THE 12-TASK CHECKLIST

Twelve pre-filled tasks walk the last mile in order: university formatting check, title page & front matter, citations complete, figures & tables numbered, plagiarism self-check, advisor sign-off, submission logistics, committee paperwork, defense presentation, practice run, post-defense revisions, final deposit.

- Every task takes a **due date** and a **status** (Not started · In progress · Done · N/A) — the days column counts down per task.
- The task texts are **yellow, editable cells**: reword them to match your university's actual process.
- The progress line at the bottom (“3 of 12 done”) keeps score. *N/A* is a status, not a cheat — use it for stages your university does not have.

LISTS — EVERY DROPDOWN, VISIBLE AND EDITABLE

What lives there

The last tab holds the dropdown values: chapter status, revision rounds R1–R4, feedback sources, revision status, checklist status. Nothing is hidden and there are no passwords — only the Dashboard is protected (without a password) so you cannot type over a formula.

Before you edit it

You may edit the values, but **the colours key on the exact text**: change “Drafting” to “Writing” and the blue pill stops recognising it. Keep entries short, and note the **chapter** dropdowns do not come from Lists at all — they read your chapter names live from the Chapters sheet.

Set C5 even if the deadline is soft. A provisional submission date makes the words-per-day tile work today; move the date later and every number follows it instantly. A pace you can see beats a pace you estimate.

Google Sheets — free, in three steps.

No Microsoft licence needed anywhere. The import takes under a minute and the file keeps working exactly as described in this guide.

1 Upload to Drive

Go to `drive.google.com` and drag `Dissertation-Writing-Tracker.xlsx` into the window (or **New** → **File upload**).

2 Open with Google Sheets

Double-click the uploaded file. If it opens in a preview instead of the editor, choose **Open with** → **Google Sheets** at the top.

3 File → Make a copy

In the Sheets menu choose **File** → **Make a copy** — this saves a native Google Sheets version. Work in the copy from now on. (**File** → **Save as Google Sheets** on the same menu does the same job.)

WHAT SURVIVES THE TRIP — AND WHAT DOES NOT

Survives

- **All formulas** — every function in the file is Sheets-compatible by design.
- **All dropdowns**, the status colours, the countdown colours and the progress bars.
- Number formats and the yellow/grey cell convention.

Does not survive

- **Print areas** — Sheets ignores imported ones; use the recipe below.
- **The Dashboard's protection**. In Sheets the Dashboard becomes typeable — so the grey-cell rule matters twice as much there. `Ctrl/Cmd+Z` undoes an accident.

PRINTING

Excel / LibreOffice: print areas are already set on every sheet — **Ctrl/Cmd+P** and you get a clean page.

Google Sheets: select the area you want (for example the Dashboard down to its last line, or Chapters columns A–J), then **File** → **Print** → **“Selected cells”** → **Fit to width**. Same result, one extra click.

SMALL KEYS THAT SAVE MINUTES

A line break **inside** a cell (for a note): **Alt+Enter** on Windows · **Ctrl+Option+Enter** on a Mac. Today's date, typed fast: **Ctrl+;** (Excel and Sheets). Undo anything: **Ctrl/Cmd+Z**.

The streak, honestly.

Streaks sell apps by being generous. This one is deliberately strict — because a number you can bargain with tells you nothing.

HOW IT COUNTS

- **One session makes the day count.** Ten minutes or three hours, drafting or cutting — a logged row is a writing day. Several sessions still count the day once.
- **The streak ends today.** It counts consecutive calendar days with at least one session, walking back from today.
- **Yesterday keeps it alive.** Logged yesterday but not yet today? The streak still stands — it is waiting for today's row, not punishing you at breakfast.
- **Miss a full day and it resets to zero.** No freezes, no repair tokens. The file does not pretend.
- **It stops counting at 30.** Past thirty consecutive days, a bigger number is no longer news — the habit is built, and the tile says so by standing still.

WHEN IT RESETS — READ THE KINDER NUMBER

A reset streak is information, not a verdict. Next to it sits “**Active days — last 7**”: on how many of the last seven days you wrote at all. A writer on a five-days-a-week rhythm sees a streak that resets every weekend — and an active-days count that calmly says 5. If the strict number stings, the kinder one is the truer picture of your rhythm. Both are on the Dashboard on purpose.

THE SAME HONESTY, EVERYWHERE IN THE FILE

The progress bars round down

A chapter at 96% shows **9 of 10 blocks** — the full bar is reserved for a true 100%. A bar that fills early flatters you out of the last thousand words; this one does not.

Nothing vanishes, nothing is invented

Overdue revisions show **negative days in red** instead of disappearing. Empty inputs show “—” instead of a made-up zero. Words-per-day never guesses: no deadline, no number.

None of this promises you will finish faster — no spreadsheet can. It promises something smaller and more useful: the state of your thesis, uninflated, every time you open the file.

If something looks wrong, start here.

Nine symptoms, nine fixes. Almost everything on this page comes down to one of three causes: a date saved as text, a chapter name that does not match, or a deleted or inserted row.

SYMPTOM	WHAT IS HAPPENING — AND THE FIX
The file looks empty or frozen in a preview	Preview windows (Drive, Etsy, Quick Look) show a cached snapshot. Open the file in Excel or Sheets — it recalculates the moment it opens.
“—” everywhere on a fresh file	That is the calm empty state, not a bug. The dashes fill in as you add chapters, goals, dates and sessions.
The dropdown arrow is missing	The arrow only shows on the selected cell. Click the cell first; if validation got lost in an import, re-import the original download.
Dates show as numbers like 46237	The cell lost its date format — the value is fine. Format the cells as a date (yyyy-mm-dd).
Streak or week tiles ignore a session	The date was saved as text , not as a date. The tell: the grey Week cell next to it stays empty, and real dates sit right-aligned. Retype the date as yyyy-mm-dd .
The deadline panel shows “—” everywhere	One due date on Chapters was entered as text. Check the due-date column: right-aligned = real date. Retype the odd one out.
A week tile rises but “Total words” does not	That session’s Chapter cell is empty, misspelled or has a stray space, so the words match no chapter. Fix the name — and after renaming a chapter, rename it in the logged sessions too (find & replace; note that pasting can bypass the dropdown).
My totals stopped moving / my new row shows no numbers	You inserted an empty row (it has no grey formulas) or typed beyond the capacity of 25 chapters · 300 sessions · 100 revision rounds. Move the entries into the next pre-filled row — and see the row rule on page 2.
I deleted whole rows and the bottom of a sheet stopped calculating	Row deletion removes formulas permanently. Re-download the original file from your Etsy purchases, copy your entries across, and from then on clear contents only.

Still stuck? Message me on Etsy — I reply within 48 hours. Tell me which sheet, which cell and what you expected to see; that is usually enough to sort it out in one reply.

Bonus · ten writing unblock prompts.

For the days the cursor just blinks. Use them on yourself, or paste one into an AI assistant together with your text. They promise nothing — they simply give the next twenty minutes a shape. Pick **one**, set a timer, start.

1 · The ugly first draft

"Write the worst acceptable version of this section in 15 minutes: no citations, no hedging, wrong words allowed. Mark every gap with [TK] and keep moving. Nothing written this way is final — it only has to exist."

6 · Argue against yourself

"Write the strongest honest objection a critical examiner could raise against this chapter's main claim. Then answer it in one paragraph. Put both — objection and answer — into the text."

2 · Reverse outline

"For each paragraph in this section, write one line: what does this paragraph claim? Then read only the one-liners. Do they form an argument in this order? Move or cut paragraphs until they do."

7 · Topic sentence last

"Write the body of the paragraph first — evidence, reasoning, example. Then ask: what does this paragraph actually show? Write that answer as its new first sentence."

3 · Tighten a paragraph

"Cut this paragraph by 10% without losing a claim. Delete throat-clearing ('It is important to note that...'), doubled hedges ('may possibly'), and any sentence that repeats the one before it."

8 · Explain it to a non-expert

"Explain this section in five sentences to someone outside your field — no jargon allowed. The sentence where you start to struggle marks the exact spot that is not yet clear in the text."

4 · Signposting

"At the start of this section, tell the reader in two sentences what it will argue and in what order. At the end, add one sentence: what has now been established, and what the next section does with it."

9 · Notes into prose

"Take your bullet notes for this section and join them using only connectives: because, however, therefore, for example. Do not polish. You are allowed to write badly on the way to writing clearly."

5 · Abstract skeleton

"Write one sentence for each: Context. Gap. Question. Method. Main finding. Why it matters. Expand a sentence only after all six exist — the skeleton first, the flesh second."

10 · End mid-sentence

"Stop today's session in the middle of a sentence you already know how to finish, and jot three words about what comes next. Tomorrow starts with typing, not with deciding."

And whichever one you pick: when the timer rings, log the session — date, chapter, minutes, words. Even a hard day moves the Dashboard.

Questions, licence, and where to find me.

FREQUENTLY ASKED

Does it work for a Masters thesis?	Yes. The file tracks the writing phase of any thesis — Masters or PhD. Fewer chapters, shorter deadlines, same mechanics.
Excel or Google Sheets — which is better?	Both work fully; every formula in the file is compatible with Excel 2016+ and Google Sheets. LibreOffice Calc works too. Pick whichever you already live in.
Can I track two projects?	Duplicate the file — one copy per thesis or per big writing project. The licence covers unlimited copies for your own work.
Can I change the dropdown values?	Yes, on the Lists sheet — but the colours key on the exact text, so keep the wording in sync (page 5).
My word count went down — is that a bug?	No. Sessions accept negative words for editing days, and totals follow honestly. Cutting is writing.
Where does my data go?	Nowhere. The file has no macros, no internet connection and no account behind it. In Excel or LibreOffice it lives entirely on your device; in Google Sheets it lives in your own Drive.
There is an updated version — how do I get it?	Re-download from your Etsy purchases page at no extra cost. Copy your entries across; the sheet layout stays stable.

LICENCE

One buyer, personal use. Use this workbook for your own theses and writing projects, in unlimited copies, on as many devices as you like. Please do not resell it, redistribute it, share it as a file, or include it in a product of your own. Thank you — small shops live on that courtesy.

SUPPORT

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ONE-LINE REMINDERS

- Yellow = you type
- Grey = it calculates
- Clear demo contents — never delete rows
- Type into the next pre-filled row
- 25 chapters · 300 sessions · 100 revisions
- Unique chapter names — no * ? ~
- Dates as yyyy-mm-dd
- Negative words allowed
- Streak caps at 30
- No macros, works offline